

# HASHKAMA WEEKLY



פרשת חקת

יא' תמוז תשפ"ו

JUNE 26, 2026

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## By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-א תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Raboisai, we begin Parshas Chukas with the ultimate chok, the Parah Adumah. The Torah tells us in Bamidbar 19:2, "Zos chukas hatorah," introducing a mitzvah that famously baffled even Shlomo Hamelech, as Chazal tell us in Yoma 14a. You take a perfectly red cow, burn it, and the ashes magically purify someone who is tamei meis. But here is the catch, the punchline that only Hakadosh Baruch Hu could write: the kohen who administers this mixture becomes tamei himself! Rashi, quoting Bamidbar Rabbah 19:1, explains that the Satan and the umos haolam mock Klal Yisroel for this. They say, "What is this mitzvah?" And we are supposed to answer, "It is a gezeiras Melech, and you have no right to question it." This is the essence of a chok. We do it simply because Hashem said so. It requires a complete nullification of our human seichel. It is like being asked to understand why the shul's kiddush club buys the expensive herring but uses the cheapest plastic forks; it defies all logic, but you just accept it. The Parah Adumah teaches us that our understanding is limited. The very vehicle that brings taharah to one Yid brings tumah to another, forcing us to admit that our mortal brains cannot comprehend the ribbono shel olam's blueprints.

This exact theme of submitting our seichel perfectly sets the stage for the tragic episode later in the parsha, the Mei Merivah. In Bamidbar 20:8, Hashem commands Moshe Rabbeinu to speak to the rock to bring forth water for Klal Yisroel. Instead, as Bamidbar 20:11 records, Moshe strikes the rock twice with his staff. The Rambam in Shemoneh Perakim, Perek 6, suggests Moshe's cheit was anger, but the classic pshat from Rashi on Bamidbar 20:12 is that Moshe missed the opportunity for a massive kiddush Hashem. If a rock, which receives no sachar or onesh, obeys Hashem's spoken word, kal vachomer a Yid should! Connect this to the Parah Adumah: the Parah Adumah demands absolute, unquestioning obedience without understanding the "why." Moshe Rabbeinu, the greatest navi, used his own seichel to calculate that hitting the rock, as he did years earlier in Shemos 17:6, was still the correct approach. He relied on past mesorah instead of the immediate gezeiras Melech. The connection is mamash striking. When we treat a chok like a mishpat, we inevitably falter. Moshe's slight deviation from the exact tzivuy shows us the danger of inserting our own logic into Hashem's commands. Even the greatest among us can stumble if they try to rationalize the instructions rather than acting with the simple emunah required by a chok.

The **practical takeaway** for us in our daily avodas Hashem is profound, yet remarkably simple. We spend far too much of our precious time acting exactly like the umos haolam, demanding perfectly logical explanations for absolutely everything in our lives, from the latest global shidduchim crisis to the gabbai's deeply mysterious Yom Kippur seating arrangements. Sometimes, we really just need to stop being a chochom and blindly follow the tzivuy. When you are asked to learn an extra seder, give more tzedakah, or simply smile at a fellow mispallel when you are completely exhausted, do not aggressively hit the rock trying to force a purely logical outcome. Just speak to it. Embrace the chok, leave the complicated cheshbonos to Hashem, and have a gut Shabbos.

## News & Simchos!

### Notice: Hashkama Update

Starting Shabbos, July 4th, Hashkama relocates to Rabbi Nussbaum's Shul (14 Sergio) at an uncompromising 7:00 AM.

What better way to privately mark a quarter-millennium of independence than voluntarily surrendering 15 minutes of sleep

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## Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

|                                               |                      |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| 2:30 pm                                       | מנחה                 |
| 6:58/8:15 pm                                  | הדלקה (Early/Late)   |
| --- pm                                        | מנחה - קבלת שבת      |
| 8:33 pm                                       | שקיעה                |
| 3:35/4:14 am                                  | עלות השחר (16.1/72)  |
| 5:26 am                                       | נץ החמה              |
| 7:15 am                                       | שחרית                |
| <b>Hot kiddush &amp; Shiur after davening</b> |                      |
| 8:37/9:13 am                                  | סיור קריאת שמע       |
| 10:04/10:28 am                                | סיור תפילה           |
| 12:59 pm                                      | חצות היום            |
| 1:37 pm                                       | מנחה גדולה (גר"א)    |
| 5:24 pm                                       | מנחה קטנה (גר"א)     |
| 6:58 pm                                       | פלג המנחה (גר"א)     |
| --- pm                                        | מנחה                 |
| 8:33 pm                                       | שקיעה                |
| 9:24/9:23 pm                                  | צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50) |
| 9:25 pm                                       | מעריב (52)           |
| 9:33/9:45 pm                                  | צה"כ (60/72)         |



## Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

|              |                    |
|--------------|--------------------|
| 2:30 pm      | מנחה               |
| 6:58/8:14 pm | הדלקה (Early/Late) |
| 8:32 pm      | שקיעה              |
| 7:00 am      | שחרית (14 Sergio)  |
| 8:32 pm      | שקיעה              |
| 9:24 pm      | מעריב (52)         |

## Parshah-ly Punny!

**Riddle: Why did the incident at Mei Merivah ultimately cost Moshe and Aharon their positions as the leaders of Klal Yisroel?**

**Answer:** They were explicitly commanded to handle the water crisis verbally, but the situation unfortunately escalated into a severe staffing problem.



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## משל ונמשל ב-אI תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

**Mashal:** A gut Shabbos. The Chafetz Chaim (Chafetz Chaim al HaTorah, Korach) offers a geishmake mashal about a wealthy gvir who decided to fund a massive, state-of-the-art pharmacy in his shtetl. He stocked it with the most expensive, imported refuos, purchased gleaming glass vials, and hired a renowned, highly trained rokeach to compound the complex prescriptions. One afternoon, while the rokeach stepped out to daven Mincha, a local am haaretz wandered behind the counter. This fellow, whose primary intellectual achievement was successfully remembering his own name on most days, decided he was perfectly qualified to mix a life-saving elixir. When the horrified gvir caught him pouring random, highly toxic powders into a mortar, the man defended himself with tremendouschutzpah. "Why are you yelling?" he protested. "I have been sweeping the floors of this pharmacy for six months! I breathe the same air as the rokeach, I look at the same bottles, and my broom touches the exact same floorboards! Why should he get all the kavod of mixing the potions while I am relegated to a mop? Are we not all equal citizens of this shtetl?" The gvir looked at him as if he had lost his mind. He explained that while every Yid in the shtetl is equally chashuv in the eyes of Hashem, mixing potent chemicals requires years of rigorous limud and a highly specialized hasagah. Giving an untrained novice the mortar and pestle does not create equality; it creates a cemetery.

**Nimshal:** The nimshal perfectly illustrates the foundational flaw in the massive machlokes orchestrated against Moshe Rabbeinu. Korach gathered two hundred and fifty prominent men, dressed them in techeiles, and presented a seemingly democratic, modern argument: "Rav lachem ki kol ha'eidah kulam kedoshim uvesocham Hashem umadua tisnasu al kehal Hashem" (Bamidbar 16:3). Korach argued that since the entire Klal Yisrael stood at Har Sinai and heard the Anochi, everyone possessed identical spiritual standing. Therefore, why should Moshe and Aharon retain the exclusive leadership roles? The Malbim (Bamidbar 16:3) explains that Korach intentionally conflated intrinsic kedushah with a functional tafkid. It is absolutely true that every Yid possesses a cheilek elokah mimaal and immense inherent holiness. However, intrinsic kedushah does not magically grant someone the authority or the specific spiritual mechanics required to serve as the Kohen Gadol or the Manhig Yisrael. Just as the untrained floor-sweeper in the pharmacy assumed that proximity to medicine equated to medical expertise, Korach assumed that possessing a holy neshamah automatically qualified him to offer the ketores. The ketores, much like a highly volatile prescription, brings immense brachah when administered by the exact right person, but delivers a catastrophic mageifah when handled by unauthorized amateurs. Korach's tragically flawed logic was rooted in a profound misunderstanding of klal dynamics; he refused to accept that a functioning tzibur requires distinct roles, and that not every member of the choir can simultaneously play the tuba.

**Practical Takeaway:** The Practical Takeaway for our own lives is remarkably relevant, especially for those of us who sit in shul and silently critique the Rav's psak because we once skimmed a footnote in a translated Sefer while waiting for the kiddush to start. We live in a dor where everyone has an internet connection, access to an English database of halacha, and a frankly terrifying amount of unearned self-confidence. It is incredibly easy to adopt the mentality of Korach and insist that kol ha'eidah kulam kedoshim. After all, we all listen to the same shiurim on double speed, we all attended a yeshiva at some point, and we all know how to vigorously argue a completely irrelevant sevara during the Shalosh Seudos. However, we must internalize that true humility means recognizing our own boundaries. Just because a person can successfully navigate the index of a Mishnah Berurah does not mean they are equipped to pasken complex shailos for the tzibur. Hashem designed Klal Yisrael to function with structure, where those who have spent decades toiling in pure limud haTorah are entrusted with the spiritual mortar and pestle. When we try to mix the refuos ourselves out of a misplaced sense of gaavah, we end up causing monumental machlokes and spiritual damage. Instead of demanding equal time behind the steering wheel, our avodah is to support our true talmidei chachamim, respect the mesorah, and perhaps focus our energy on making sure we actually show up to shacharis before Barchu.

# GOOD SHABBUS!